SURVEY OF THE NEW TESTAMENT

Bethesda Bible Institute Academic Textbook Series

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This comprehensive 15-page academic textbook surveys the 27 books of the New Testament canon. It provides historical-grammatical context, authorship analysis, theological themes, structural outlines, and practical pastoral applications for seminary students.

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CHAPTER 1: WORLD OF THE NEW TESTAMENT

Historical, Political, and Religious Background

Between Malachi and Matthew lies roughly 400 years of intertestamental history that shaped the first-century world.

1. Political Context: The Roman Empire provided Pax Romana, paved roads, and maritime security for rapid gospel spread.
2. Cultural Context: Hellenization under Alexander the Great established Koine Greek as the universal trade language.
3. Religious Context: Synagogues, the Sanhedrin, Pharisees, Sadducees, Essenes, and Messianic expectation prepared Israel for the arrival of Jesus Christ in the fullness of time (Gal 4:4).

CHAPTER 2: THE GOSPEL OF MATTHEW

Jesus the Promised Messiah and King

Author: Matthew (Levi), former tax collector and Apostle.
Audience: Primarily Jewish believers in Palestine and Syria.
Key Verse: Matthew 5:17 - "Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them."

Structure: Five major teaching discourses echoing the Torah:
- Sermon on the Mount (Ch 5-7)
- Missionary Discourse (Ch 10)
- Parables of the Kingdom (Ch 13)
- Community & Forgiveness (Ch 18)
- Olivet Discourse & Great Commission (Ch 24-28)

CHAPTER 3: THE GOSPEL OF MARK

Jesus the Suffering Servant of the Lord

Author: John Mark, companion of Peter and Paul.
Audience: Roman Gentile Christians facing persecution.
Key Verse: Mark 10:45 - "For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."

Distinctive Features:
- Fast-paced narrative marked by the word "immediately" (euthys).
- Emphasizes Jesus actions, miracles, and authority over demons.
- Centers on the Messianic Secret and the cost of discipleship.
- Chapters 11-16 focus intensively on Passion Week in Jerusalem.

CHAPTER 4: THE GOSPEL OF LUKE

Jesus the Compassionate Savior of All Nations

Author: Luke, the beloved physician and historian (Col 4:14).
Audience: Theophilus and broader Greco-Roman world.
Key Verse: Luke 19:10 - "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."

Key Theological Emphases:
- Universal scope of salvation for Gentiles, Samaritans, and poor.
- Prominent role of the Holy Spirit and persevering prayer.
- Unique parables: Good Samaritan (Ch 10), Prodigal Son (Ch 15).
- Carefully researched historical prologue (Luke 1:1-4).

CHAPTER 5: THE GOSPEL OF JOHN

Jesus the Eternal Word Made Flesh

Author: John the Apostle, the disciple whom Jesus loved.
Key Verse: John 20:31 - "These are written so that you may
believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that
by believing you may have life in his name."

Structure:
- Prologue: The Eternal Logos (John 1:1-18)
- Book of Signs: Seven Miracles & Seven "I AM" Statements (Ch 2-12)
- Book of Glory: Upper Room Discourse & High Priestly Prayer (Ch 13-17)
- Passion, Resurrection, and Restoration of Peter (Ch 18-21)

CHAPTER 6: THE ACTS OF THE APOSTLES

The Holy Spirit and Global Witness

Author: Luke (Volume 2 of Luke-Acts).

Key Verse: Acts 1:8 - "You will be my witnesses in Jerusalem
and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth."

Threefold Geographical Expansion:

1. Witness in Jerusalem (Chapters 1-7): Pentecost & Peter.
2. Witness in Judea & Samaria (Chapters 8-12): Philip & Cornelius.
3. Witness to the Ends of the Earth (Chapters 13-28):
   Pauls three missionary journeys across Asia Minor, Greece,
   and his final testimony in Rome.

CHAPTER 7: THE EPISTLE TO THE ROMANS

The Righteousness of God by Faith

Author: The Apostle Paul (written from Corinth around AD 57).

Key Verse: Romans 1:16-17 - "The righteous shall live by faith."

Theological Outline:

- Chapters 1-3: Universal sinfulness of Gentiles and Jews.
- Chapters 3-5: Justification by grace through faith in Christ.
- Chapters 6-8: Sanctification and life in the Spirit (Rom 8:1).
- Chapters 9-11: Gods sovereign plan for Israel and Gentiles.
- Chapters 12-16: Living sacrifices and Christian community.

CHAPTER 8: CORINTHIAN & GALATIAN EPISTLES

Church Order, Resurrection, and Christian Freedom

1 Corinthians: Addresses church divisions, moral purity, the Lords Supper, spiritual gifts (Ch 12-14), and the bodily resurrection of Christ and believers (Ch 15).

2 Corinthians: Paul defends his apostolic ministry, teaching that Gods power is made perfect in weakness (2 Cor 12:9).

Galatians: Defends justification by faith alone against legalism and highlights the fruit of the Spirit (Gal 5:22-23).

CHAPTER 9: THE PRISON EPISTLES

Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, Philemon

Written during Pauls Roman imprisonment (approx. AD 60-62):

- Ephesians: The cosmic unity of the Church as Christs Body and the spiritual armor of God (Eph 6:10-18).
- Philippians: Joy in Christ under trial and the Kenosis hymn of Christs humility and exaltation (Phil 2:5-11).
- Colossians: The absolute supremacy and sufficiency of Christ over all creation and principalities (Col 1:15-20).
- Philemon: Gospel reconciliation between master and slave.

CHAPTER 10: THESSALONIAN & PASTORAL EPISTLES

Eschatological Hope and Church Leadership

1 & 2 Thessalonians: Comfort believers regarding the Second Coming of Christ, the resurrection of the dead, and faithful diligence while awaiting the Day of the Lord.

1 & 2 Timothy and Titus (Pastoral Epistles):

- Qualifications for elders/overseers and deacons (1 Tim 3).
- Guarding sound doctrine against false teaching.
- Inspiration and sufficiency of Scripture (2 Tim 3:16-17).
- Pauls final charge: "I have fought the good fight" (2 Tim 4:7).

CHAPTER 11: HEBREWS & GENERAL EPISTLES

Christ Our High Priest and Living Faith

- Hebrews: Christ is superior to angels, Moses, and the Levitical priesthood; He mediates the New Covenant (Heb 8-10).
- James: Authentic faith produces works of mercy and wisdom.
- 1 & 2 Peter: Hope in suffering and guarding against heresy.
- 1, 2, 3 John: Walking in light, love, and truth; assurance of eternal life (1 John 5:13).
- Jude: Contending earnestly for the faith once delivered.

CHAPTER 12: THE BOOK OF REVELATION

The Victorious Lamb and New Creation

Author: The Apostle John on the island of Patmos (AD 95).

Key Verse: Revelation 21:5 - "Behold, I am making all things new."

Apocalyptic Structure:

- Letters to the Seven Churches of Asia Minor (Ch 2-3)
- Throne Room Worship & the Worthy Lamb (Ch 4-5)
- Seals, Trumpets, and Bowls of Judgment (Ch 6-16)
- Return of the King of Kings (Ch 19)
- New Heaven, New Earth, and New Jerusalem (Ch 21-22)

APPENDIX: GLOSSARY & STUDY QUESTIONS

Key Exegetical Terms & Review

Key Theological Terms:

1. Justification (Dikaiosis) - Declared righteous by faith.
2. Propitiation (Hilasterion) - Christs atoning sacrifice.
3. Sanctification (Hagiasmos) - Set apart in holiness.
4. Eschatology - Doctrine of the last things and renewal.

Review Questions:

1. Compare the Christological focus of Matthew and John.
2. Summarize Pauls argument in Romans 3:21-26.
3. How does Hebrews 9 explain Christs once-for-all sacrifice?